order to abandon Tawang, he privately felt that Tawang should be held, but he neither had the confidence nor the conviction to issue the order himself. As he took off, he told Niranjan Prasad to do as he liked, as it was ‘his battle and his command’. However, shortly after landing in Tezpur, Bogey Sen spoke on the phone with Thapar, and after briefing him of the prevailing situation in Tawang, he demanded that Niranjan Prasad be sacked immediately as he had ‘run away from Zimithang’.

Back in Milaktong-la, 1 Sikh firmed up its plan for breaking contact with the Chinese and withdrawing to Jang. Delta Company was ordered to hold Tongpeng-la till 3 p.m., after which they were to fall back on Milaktong-la. This was a tricky manoeuvre, but with the help of Gosal’s guns deployed at Mi-la, it was executed with precision. Through the day, the artillery had fired almost 600 rounds at the enemy. Delta Company then deployed around Milaktong-la where it would continue to be the rearguard as the rest of 1 Sikh, including Bravo Company and Delta Company, less a platoon of 4 Garhwal Rifles, began to pull back at last light. The Chinese continued to bombard Milaktong-la but were not willing to close the gap with Delta Company again. At 11 p.m., Kaushik’s men abandoned Milaktong-la and started the long descent towards Jang. Delta Company of 1 Sikh had shown the Indian Army how to fight. Unfortunately, none of the senior officers were watching.

At 10.30 a.m. that morning, Lieutenant Colonel B. M. Bhattacharjea was chafing at the bit when he received orders to pull his battalion out of Tawang. Even though Delta Company minus a platoon was supporting 1 Sikh at Milaktong-la, neither Alpha nor Charlie Company had reported any contact with the Chinese, even though Tawang was awash with rumours about Chinese columns surrounding the monastery and the town. Alpha Company was immediately ordered to fall back on Tawang and was tasked with holding Tawang till last light, after which it was to fall back on Jang.

By the afternoon, all rear elements were withdrawing from Tawang while Mi-4 helicopters were ferrying women and children out of Tawang and flying them across Se-la to Dirang Dzong. Till that very morning, no thought had been given to evacuating Tawang; within hours, the precipitate withdrawal created mayhem. There were hundreds of men from the Assam Rifles and the Pioneers who, along with civilians and even lamas from the monasteries, now fled towards Jang with whatever they could carry.